that in South India divisions began to emerge between the traditionalists and the modernisers, both groups led by Sayyids claiming direct descent from the Prophet through his daughter Fatima.

The modernisers took their lead from a line of Sufi preachers that went back to Sayyid Ahmad Jalauddin, who had emigrated from Bukhara to Malabar in the sixteenth century to play a leading role in the spread of Sufi teaching throughout India. The traditionalists looked for leadership from a very different group of Sayyids who came to be known in Malabar as Thangals, a local honorific applied only to Sayyids.

The first of these Thangals was the Islamic scholar Sayyid Alavi Mouladaveel Thangal, whose house and tomb in Mambaram, south of Calicut, are now important places of pilgrimage for Sunni Muslims in South India. His arrival in Calicut from Yemen as a young man in about 1770 marked the beginnings of increased conservatism within the Muslim community in South India. As Sayyids, he and his successors were considered religiously superior to the long-settled Mappilas and they came to be accepted as the leaders of the Muslims in the region, with their heartland at Mambaram and other centres at Malappuram, Ponnai and Calicut. More significantly, they were far more fundamentalist in their thinking than their predecessors, being influenced by the opposition to all form of perceived innovation emerging in central Arabia that its critics called Wahhabism.

Portrayals of Muslim women in South India up to the middle of the nineteenth century show them following local styles of dress, usually with their hair covered but never their faces concealed. As a general rule, only high-born women, Hindu as well as Muslim, then followed the patriarchal custom of purdah or *ghunghat*, remaining in seclusion indoors and veiling their faces in public. This was more marked in the north and in the Sultanates south of the